

Shamet off the Bench 2.0

2024-25 Season Preview

Finn Irving

Eastern Conference

- 1. Boston Celtics**
- 2. New York Knicks**
- 3. Cleveland Cavaliers**
- 4. Orlando Magic**
- 5. Indiana Pacers**
- 6. Milwaukee Bucks**
- 7. Philadelphia 76ers**
- 8. Toronto Raptors**
- 9. Miami Heat**
- 10. Charlotte Hornets**
- 11. Atlanta Hawks**
- 12. Chicago Bulls**
- 13. Brooklyn Nets**
- 14. Washington Wizards**
- 15. Detroit Pistons**

Western Conference

- 1. Minnesota Timberwolves**
- 2. Oklahoma City Thunder**
- 3. New Orleans Pelicans**
- 4. Dallas Mavericks**
- 5. Denver Nuggets**
- 6. Phoenix Suns**
- 7. Memphis Grizzlies**
- 8. Sacramento Kings**
- 9. Los Angeles Lakers**
- 10. Houston Rockets**
- 11. Golden State Warriors**
- 12. Los Angeles Clippers**
- 13. Portland Trailblazers**
- 14. Utah Jazz**
- 15. San Antonio Spurs**

East

#1 – Boston Celtics

General Thoughts – The Defending Champs bring back their entire team from last year. It is literally the exact same team. They rolled through the playoffs last year with relative ease. Holiday/White/Brown/Tatum/Porzingis is the best starting lineup in the NBA for the second straight year. Brown and Tatum do their thing, playing night in and night out, alternating who is the best player on the court. Derrick White is the #1 example of a “Winning Player” in the entire NBA. They will need Kristaps Porzingis to stay healthy, he is an X-Factor of sorts for this squad. Key role players Payton Pritchard and Sam Hauser will look to continue to build off their success off the bench. This Celtics lineup really is star-studded. They put together one of the greatest seasons of all time last year, and capped it off with one of the most dominant playoff runs I’ve ever seen. If they stay healthy, it would be foolish to think they won’t be heavy favorites to go back-to-back and win another title in 2025. They have the proper setup to start a dynasty and win multiple titles over the next few years.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Jrue Holiday

SG: Derrick White

SF: Jaylen Brown

PF: Jayson Tatum

C: Al Horford

Additions – None

Losses – Oshae Brissett (No one)

#2 – New York Knicks

General Thoughts – I’m not sure what of the Knicks off-season. There is a lot of roster turnover which is rather unnecessary in my opinion. I’m not a big fan of Bridges or Towns. I understand why they made the trades, especially the Towns one, with Mitchell “Big Meech” Robinson being out until December or January. We all know about my love of Julius Randle. Losing him is probably not as big of a loss for the team as I think it is, but it is still a loss. I think they will really miss DiVincenzo and Hartenstein. They are both winning players that bring a lot of grit and unselfishness to the team. A real key for this team is a underrated move they made late in the offseason, signing veteran Landry Shamet to a 1 year deal. Having Shamet coming off the bench exponentially increases the winning potential of any team. (UPDATE: LANDRY SHAMET

DISLOCATED HIS SHOULDER AND THEN WAS RELEASED BY THE KNICKS. Some team is going to make a wonderful pick up off of the waiver wire). So, I think that was an excellent move. Definitely their smartest of the offseason. This team is going to win games, there's no doubt about that. I have doubts about their continuity, however. I'd say they have a slight chance to win it all, but would deem it rather unlikely.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Jalen Brunson

SG: Mikal Bridges

SF: OG Anunoby

PF: Josh Hart

C: Karl-Anthony Towns

Additions – Mikal Bridges, Karl-Anthony Towns, Cam Payne, **LANDRY SHAMET**

Losses – **JULIUS RANDLE**, Donte DiVincenzo, Isaiah Hartenstein, Bojan Bogdanovic, Alec Burks

#3 – Cleveland Cavaliers

General Thoughts – This is the exact same team as last year. They did virtually nothing in the offseason, other than extending some of their key players, like Donovan Mitchell and Isaac Okoro. Since they have the same team, I'll project them to do the same thing as I did last year. I think they are quite good, but not good enough to win a title. They have offensive issues, which hurt them in the playoffs against Boston; they had no chance to keep up with their high-octane offense. I think Donovan Mitchell is a worse player than the media's perception of him. I do not believe that he is good enough to be the superstar on a title-winning team. The most fun part about this team by far is the 7-foot duo of Evan Mobley and Jarrett Allen. Both are excellent defenders and A+ athletes. Mobley and Darius Garland both have a lot of trouble staying healthy. If this team wants any chance of making a deep playoff run, they both need to be at full strength. They have a solid bench containing 3-point shooters such as Sam Merrill and Georges Niang, and Caris LeVert, who has the ability to get red-hot and score a lot of points on occasion. The only real change this team made in the offseason was firing Head Coach JB Bickerstaff and hiring long time Golden State assistant Kenny Atkinson. He is a great coach and I believe he will bring the best out of this team. I don't think they can win the title, but I do think they have a rock-solid team that will win a lot of games in the regular season.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Darius Garland

SG: Donovan Mitchell

SF: Max Strus

PF: Evan Mobley

C: Jarrett Allen

Additions – None

Losses – Marcus Morris

#4 – Orlando Magic

General Thoughts – This was a real surprise team last year, putting together a great season, earning the #5 seed in the East and taking the Cavaliers to 7 games before ultimately falling short. I was disappointed they performed so well, as it lost me the ability to consume an absolutely delectable pack of circus peanuts. Instead, I had to buy them. They bring back all of their best players, after signing Franz Wagner to an extension in the off-season. Paolo & Franz make for a formidable 6'10" duo, each with great scoring ability. Jalen Suggs and Cole Anthony each made a jump last year, strengthening the Orlando backcourt. They signed Kentavious Caldwell-Pope in the offseason, which I think is a great signing. He is a winning player, providing excellent 3 & D abilities. He's been deep in the playoffs before, so he knows how to win, which is important to have on an otherwise young & inexperienced team. They're a good, hard-nosed team who I think could win a playoff series, maybe even two. However, I don't think they have the star-power necessary to go any further than this in the playoffs.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Jalen Suggs

SG: Kentavious Caldwell-Pope

SF: Franz Wagner

PF: Paolo Banchero

C: Wendell Carter Jr.

Additions – Kentavious Caldwell-Pope

Losses – Joe Ingles, Markelle Fultz,

#5 – Indiana Pacers

General Thoughts – This Pacers making a run to the 2023-24 Eastern Conference Finals was definitely not something I, or most other people, had on their radar! They bring back pretty much the exact same squad, which is one of the deeper ones in the NBA. I believe Tyrese Haliburton is purely a system player. Their fast-paced offense leads to all of his stat accumulation. Nembhard and McConnell were two of the best backup guards in the NBA last year, and when Haliburton was hurt, they put up very similar numbers, especially in the assists category. Regardless, this team runs 10+ deep, with solid players such as Benn Mathurin, Obi Toppin, Ben Sheppard and Isaiah Jackson coming in off the bench. This depth allows them to play the run and gun style which they do. Pascal Siakam was a great addition at the deadline last year. Haliburton and Myles Turner are both injury-prone, so it will be important that they both stay healthy if this team wants to make another run. However, they certainly have the ability to make it back to the ECF. They also need to defend their coveted In-Season Tournament title, winning the Inaugural NBA Cup last year.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Tyrese Haliburton

SG: Andrew Nembhard

SF: Aaron Nesmith

PF: Pascal Siakam

C: Myles Turner

Additions – None

Losses – Jalen Smith, Doug McDermott

#6 – Milwaukee Bucks

General Thoughts – I thought this team was the best in the entire NBA heading into last season. However, they put up a bit of a stinker of a season, getting knocked out in the first round of the playoffs. Part of this definitely had to do with the mid-season abrupt firing of coach Adrian Griffin and hiring of Doc Rivers. They were 30-13 prior to this, and finished the season off 17-19. They didn't do anything big this offseason, following a very tumultuous one last year. The additions of Gary Trent Jr, Taurean Prince and Delon Wright for Patrick Beverley, Malik Beasley and Jae Crowder are largely lateral moves. Their core is still very strong, with Lillard/Giannis making up one of the best tandems in the NBA. At full health, I still think Giannis is as unstoppable as anyone in the league. He is good enough to make any team he is on worthy of title consideration. But I don't think this is the team to do it. Dame began to show signs of regression last year, with his stats decreasing pretty much across the board. Khris Middleton is never healthy, having played only 88 games over the last two seasons. One piece of theirs I

would be curious to see them unleash a bit is Andre Jackson Jr. He is probably a top 10 athlete in the entire NBA, and I feel as though he could give their team a dynamic boost. All in all, I'd say this squad has an outside chance to be really good again, if all the pieces fall into place. If they don't I would project a decent season, with a first or second round exit.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Damian Lillard

SG: Gary Trent Jr

SF: Khris Middleton

PF: Giannis Antetokounmpo

C: Brook Lopez

Additions – Gary Trent Jr, Taurean Prince, Delon Wright

Losses – Patrick Beverley, Malik Beasley, Jae Crowder, Thanasis Antetokounmpo (MAJOR LOSS)

#7 – Philadelphia 76ers

General Thoughts – Nothing will ever make me like the 76ers. Joel Embiid has replaced James Harden as my least favorite player in the NBA. There is nothing I like less than watching him flail around all game. Additionally, I do not think this team is very good, despite the hype surrounding them. They probably had the most roster turnover in the league this offseason, behind maybe the Knicks. Things have not gotten off to a good start. Paul George has already injured his knee, Embiid is already saying that he won't play back-to-backs, and promising rookie Jared "TikTok" McCain took a brutal fall the other day and may miss some time. They have 6'5" Caleb Martin penciled in as their starting Power Forward, and a bench filled with crusty veterans like Reggie Jackson, Eric Gordon, Andre Drummond and Kyle Lowry. I do think Tyrese Maxey is really good. His numbers have gotten better each of his 4 NBA seasons, and he's turned into a superstar caliber player. With wimpy George and Embiid, chances are he will have to shoulder the load for the team a majority of the regular season. I'm very happy to see Guerschon Yabusele in the NBA after his superhuman efforts for Team France this year in the Summer Olympics. I will be rooting for him to do well on this team. They have the star power to contend in the playoffs, but I think they will be unable to compile a great regular season record, and will fall victim to one of the top dogs in the first round.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Tyrese Maxey

SG: Kelly Oubre Jr

SF: Paul George

PF: Caleb Martin

C: Joel Embiid

Additions – Paul George, Andre Drummond, Caleb Martin, Eric Gordon, Guerschon Yabusele, Reggie Jackson

Losses – De’Anthony Melton, Buddy Hield, Nicolas Batum, Tobias Harris, Cam Payne, BBall Paul Reed,

#8 – Toronto Raptors

General Thoughts – I am most likely higher on the Raptors than anyone else... but I like their team. Scottie Barnes emerged last season as a bonafide #1 option, taking a huge leap in almost every category. They really emptied the chamber at the trade deadline, dealing OG Anunoby and Pascal Siakam. In return, they picked up Immanuel Quickley, RJ Barrett, and Bruce Brown, along with a smattering of first round picks. Now, I don’t think RJ Barrett is very good. I watched him on the Knicks and he is a rather bad player. Bruce Brown is a good role player. But Quickley is the real gem they grabbed in these deals. He is a dynamic scorer who can put up points in bunches. He thrived once he was traded to them, averaging 18.6/4.8/6.8 and making 3 threes a game at a 40% clip. I think he has All-Star potential. Their big options are very middling, with Poeltl, Olynyk and Chris “Slim Duck” Boucher, but I think they are good enough to get the job done. Gradey Dick is an absolute sniper. I think if he is given the proper opportunity this year, he can be a key player for this team. Their bench is solid enough. They acquired Davion Mitchell in the Jalen McDaniels trade. He is an A+ defender, but offers little else. Ochai Agbaji was an excellent player in college, leading Kansas to the 2022 National Championship. He hasn’t been given much of an opportunity in the NBA yet. Ja’Kobe Walter was their first-round pick. He was really good as a freshman on Baylor last year, and should be able to have an instant impact on this team. The bottom of the East is just dreadful. While I think most are lumping the Raptors in with the 6-way dumpster fire at the bottom of the standings, I believe they will emerge from the pack and be much better than anyone thinks. I predict a playoff appearance and a record above .500.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Immanuel Quickley

SG: Gradey Dick

SF: RJ Barrett

PF: Scottie Barnes

C: Jakob Poeltl

Additions – Davion Mitchell

Losses – Jalen McDaniels, Gary Trent Jr.

#9 – Miami Heat

General Thoughts – On paper, this Heat team doesn't look super great, but isn't that how it always is? I feel like I would be foolish to count this team out. However, I think this team is especially thin, even for a Heat roster. They were unable to get anything going last year, as it seemed as though one of their stars was out for almost every game of the season. Rumor has it that they are going to be following a Houston Rockets "layups and threes, nothing else" strategy this season. I have heard that even Bam Adebayo will be joining in on the barrage, despite only shooting 0.6 threes per game last season. Jimmy Butler has been a playoff hero for them, but has never played more than 64 games in the regular season as a member of the Heat. It would be massive for this squad if he is able to suit up and play 75+ games this season. Terry Rozier was a bad deadline acquisition. He doesn't fit in with the Heat mentality whatsoever. Tyler Herro is rocking a sick buzzcut this year. He also has a lot of trouble staying on the court. If they make it to the playoffs, Erik Spoelstra-lead teams are always dangerous. This team doesn't appear to have the same kick to it as past years though. I wouldn't be surprised if they don't make it out of the Play-In Tournament.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Terry Rozier

SG: Tyler Herro

SF: Jimmy Butler

PF: Nikola Jovic

C: Bam Adebayo

Additions – Alec Burks

Losses – Caleb Martin, Patty Mills, Delon Wright

#10 – Charlotte Hornets

General Thoughts – Someone has to make it to the play-in out of the 6 dregs of the East. I believe it will be the Charlotte Hornets. They are almost always dysfunctional and injury-prone, but they do have some talent. Mark Williams is a really good big, and LaMelo Ball puts up good

stats, whether empty or not. However, they played 22 (Ball) and 19 (Williams) games last season. Obviously, if they do this again, this team will be horrible. But if the two of them can stay on the court, that is a great start for this squad. Miles Bridges came straight from prison and put up a really good season, averaging 21 ppg and 7 rpg. Having him back also strengthens this team significantly. I was critical of their pick of Brandon Miller, but he put together a strong rookie season, averaging 17 ppg, and improving as the season went on. I suspect he will continue to grow and should average about 20 ppg this season. Josh Green was a nice addition from the Mavericks in the offseason. He is a good 3 and D role player, who can bring a bit of winning experience to this roster. Their second unit (Micic, Mann, Cody Martin, Grant Williams, and Nick Richards) is compiled of solid role players. Micic and Mann both did well after being acquired at the deadline in the Gordon Hayward salary dump deal. Martin and Williams bring some attitude, peskiness and 3 & D ability off the bench, while Richards is a rather standard backup big. Their 6th overall pick, Tidjane Salaun, is almost an entire year younger than me, so I don't suspect he will make much of an impact this season. But he is big and athletic, so there is projectability there. Lots of projecting/banking on good health of this team... but if you squint, you can see the makings of a solid team.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: LaMelo Ball

SG: Brandon Miller

SF: Josh Green

PF: Miles Bridges

C: Mark Williams

Additions – Josh Green, Taj Gibson

Losses – Devonte' Graham, Davis Bertans

#11 – Atlanta Hawks

General Thoughts – This team made their plans very clear by shipping Dejounte Murray to the Pelicans in the offseason. They managed to luck their way into the #1 pick last year with very low odds, but their grand reward was Zaccharie Risacher. They will be fully tanking in an effort to get Cooper Flagg (Sag for Flagg). However, I think several other teams are well ahead of them in that quest. They still have a decent amount of talent on their team. While I think Trae Young is overrated, he is still pretty good and will put up points and assists. Jalen Johnson emerged as a breakout player last season prior to getting injured, more than doubling his points, rebounds, assists and steals numbers from the season before. Clint Capela has been a serviceable NBA big for quite some time now. There was lots of talk about Onyeka Okongwu having a breakout

season last year, with them trading away John Collins. However, this did not come to fruition at all... his numbers looked no different. Dyson Daniels was one of the pieces they received in the Murray trade. He is an extremely projectable young guard. At 6'8" and only 21 years old, the former 8th overall pick has a knack for grabbing steals, and I am expecting him to take a big jump this season. Maybe Risacher will be good, but I certainly don't expect it. I mean, just look at him. That will most likely go down as a total waste of a #1 pick. Chances are, this team is half decent for the first half of the season, then does an absolute fire sale at the trade deadline, and puts up a terrible record in the second half. However, I think they will still finish above several other teams, despite their best efforts not to.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Trae Young

SG: Dyson Daniels

SF: De'Andre Hunter

PF: Jalen Johnson

C: Clint Capela

Additions – Dyson Daniels, Larry Nance Jr, Cody Zeller

Losses – Dejounte Murray, AJ Griffin, Saddiq Bey

#12 – Chicago Bulls

General Thoughts – This team certainly wants to tank. They traded away Alex Caruso and DeMar DeRozan in the offseason. Everyone thought they would trade Zach LaVine at the trade deadline last year, but they ended up holding onto him. The biggest positive for the Bulls last year was that Coby White blossomed into a really good player; scoring 19.1 ppg and coming in second in the Most Improved Player voting (Behind Tyrese Maxey). He looks to be the focal point of this team for this year and maybe the next few. Nikola Vucevic is a steady, unexciting player. He's put up almost the exact same season for 3 straight years. LaVine barely played last year, and I would be shocked if he is on this team past the deadline. I wouldn't be surprised if they deal both him and Vucevic. Josh Giddey didn't fit in on Oklahoma City's team, but he should get a chance to prove himself in Chicago. He's still only 21 years old, I could see him putting together a solid season for them. They used their first-round pick on Matas Buzelis, which was one of my favorite picks in the draft. I think he is going to be a good NBA player. He's long and lanky, very athletic, and can shoot the 3-ball. I don't know how much he'll play early in the year, but when they empty the tank at the deadline, he should get some good run in the back half of the season. This team will be ardently trying to lose all year long. They have enough

talent that I think it will keep them above the bottom 3 teams, but much like the Hawks, they will probably be awful down the stretch of the season.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Josh Giddey

SG: Coby White

SF: Zach LaVine

PF: Patrick Williams

C: Nikola Vucevic

Additions – Josh “18 and Under” Giddey, Jalen Smith, Chris Duarte, Talen Horton-Tucker

Losses – Alex Caruso, Andre Drummond, DeMar DeRozan,

#13 – Brooklyn Nets

General Thoughts – The Brooklyn Nets, without a shadow of doubt, win the “Team I least want to watch play a game of basketball this season” award. They are going to be terrible, they have no exciting young players, and they don’t even have funny entertainment value for being bad. I don’t even know where I would start if I was rebuilding this team. I feel as though there are 0 players on this roster that I would want on a team if I was trying to win a championship. If I had to pick someone, I guess I would pick Nic Claxton. He is a bit of a “Dollar General Rudy Gobert.” They have him signed for the next 4 seasons, so I suppose they feel that way as well. Players such as Cam Johnson and Cam Thomas will be putting up lots of shots at a terrible percentage. Dennis Schroder, Dorian Finney-Smith, and Bojan Bogdanovic are crusty old veterans with no excitement value attached to them. The only funny thing about this team is Ben Simmons, but he’ll most likely play 25 or less games, so that won’t even be something to enjoy. This team is straight up awful. I have them above the Wizards and Pistons, but I could definitely see them being the worst team in the league.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Dennis Schroder

SG: Cam Thomas

SF: Cameron Johnson

PF: Dorian Finney-Smith

C: Nic Claxton

Additions – Bojan Bogdanovic, Shake Milton, Ziaire Williams

Losses – Mikal Bridges, Dennis Smith Jr, Lonnie Walker

#14 – Washington Wizards

General Thoughts – The centerpiece and golden child of the Inaugural writing of Shamet off the Bench, the Wizards did nothing but make me look like a fool, recording an abysmal 15-67 record, proving all my critics 100% correct. This year, they are getting no such love from me. The only reason I don't have them stuffed at #15 is because I somehow think Detroit will be worse. They got rid of their 3 best players over the course of last season (Gafford, Jones, Avdija) and got peanuts in return. I really hate the Avdija trade. He ended the season very strong for them and appeared to be figured it out finally. Then they ship him away immediately after. Their random signing of Jonas Valanciunas gives them a solid center, but that isn't going to push the needle for this squad. They still have the terrible tandem of Poole and Kuzma who will be shooting approximately 40 shots per game (and making about 12-15). To top it all off, they flushed their #2 pick down the toilet by taking horrible Alex Sarr. He is already known far and wide for his 0-15 Summer League game. Theoretically, he probably should be good. But he is on the Washington Wizards, so I expect him to be terrible. With bad teams, I like to hone in on who they could build around. I think Bilal Coulibaly has the intangibles of someone that could play a role on a winning team. He is only 20 years old, and averaged nearly 1 three/steal/block per game in his rookie season. He needs to improve offensively, as he averaged 8.4 ppg on only 7 shots per game, but it is easy to project him as a player who could be quite good in 2-3 seasons. Sorry Wizards, but you aren't making the playoffs this year, or the next year, or probably the year after that either.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Jordan Poole

SG: Bilal Coulibaly

SF: Kyle Kuzma

PF: Alex Sarr

C: Jonas Valanciunas

Additions – Malcolm Brogdon, Jonas Valanciunas, Saddiq Bey

Losses – Deni Avdija, Tyus Jones, **Landry Shamet**

#15 – Detroit Pistons

General Thoughts – The Pistons may never leave this 15th spot. Nobody is better at being terrible than the Detroit Pistons. They are led by Cade Cunningham, who is proclaimed to be a “star”. He is not actually a star; he is just on a team where he gets to shoot 20+ times a game. However, they are paying him as if he is the biggest star. Their big addition this offseason is perennial joke Tobias Harris. He’ll most likely be very happy in Detroit, where he’ll be free to hoist up many shots a game. They used their 5th overall pick on G-League Ignite’s very own Ron Holland. There is no way he is going to be a good player... he’ll most likely just join the wasteland of other terrible picks. Their best player is Jalen Duren. He puts up solid numbers when he is healthy (13.8 ppg, 11.6 rpg), but has a hard time staying on the court. I also think Jaden Ivey has the potential to be a key contributor. Monty Williams had him in the doghouse last year, wildly varying his minutes, giving many of them to horrific Killian Hayes. If he is given the freedom to do his thing, I could see him taking a big jump this year. I would also like to note that Detroit signed head coach Monty Williams to a 6-year, 78.5-million-dollar contract, and promptly fired him after 1 season. Their new coach, JB Bickerstaff, will look to make lemonade out of lemons, but man oh man, life has given him some sour lemons.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Cade Cunningham

SG: Jaden Ivey

SF: Ausar Thompson

PF: Tobias Harris

C: Jalen Duren

Additions – Tobias Harris, Paul “BBall Paul” Reed, Tim Hardaway Jr., Malik Beasley

Losses – James Wiseman, Quentin Grimes, Evan Fournier, Malachi “50 Burger” Flynn

West

#1 – Minnesota Timberwolves

General Thoughts – The Minnesota Timberwolves will win the 2024-25 NBA Championship. Wow. That’s a bold way to start off a team’s write-up for the season. But it is what I believe in. This team has star-power, they have depth, they have a great coach in Chris Finch. They made a

deep run last season, even knocking off the defending champion Denver Nuggets in an epic Game 7 comeback. Now that they have that valuable playoff experience, they'll be ready to go all the way this year. Obviously, everything revolves around Anthony Edwards. He is incredible, super exciting to watch, and I think he will be even better this season than last. The Towns-Randle/DiVincenzo trade was an interesting one. Even with my unbiased opinion, I think the Timberwolves won the trade. I've never been a fan of KAT, and he had games last year in the playoffs where he just disappeared. Randle is Randle, I won't say too much about him. But getting DiVincenzo as well in that trade was a really sneaky addition. He shot 40% from three on nearly 9 attempts per game, including lots of difficult shots. This team has so much depth. Players like DiVincenzo and Naz "Jelly Fam" Reid coming off the bench are absolute studs and would start on most other teams in the league. I understand the concern about Rudy Gobert... and I agree that he often looks rather terrible and goofy. But he is good at what he does, which is playing defense and blocking shots. They should be able to run lineups with Randle at the 4 and Reid at the 5 if need be, to cover up Gobert's deficiencies. I am not sure how much they will play, but they also picked up two extremely talented offensive rookies, in Rob Dillingham and Terrance Shannon Jr. I wouldn't be surprised if they forced their way into the lineup and picked up some minutes. I love everything about this team and am excited to watch them push for a championship.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Mike Conley

SG: Anthony Edwards

SF: Jalen McDaniels

PF: Julius Randle

C: Rudy Gobert

Additions – JULIUS RANDLE, Donte DiVincenzo, Joe Ingles, Keita Bates-Diop

Losses – Karl-Anthony Towns, Kyle "Slo-Mo" Anderson, Monte Morris

#2 – Oklahoma City Thunder

General Thoughts – This is a dangerous team. Led by SGA, the Thunder have a legitimate chance to win it all this year. They broke out last year, winning 57 games, but suffered an earlier loss than they would have liked in the playoffs. This is typical of any young team in the NBA. Now they have been there, and will be back this year with a vengeance. They made two great moves in the offseason, trading for Alex Caruso and signing free agent Isaiah Hartenstein. A good center was what this team was missing, and Hartenstein is the ultimate winning player. I watched him play a lot last year, and he has to lead the league in "times that a player dives on

the ground". He embodies heart and hustle, and Caruso brings the exact same intangibles to the table. Hartenstein just broke his hand, and will be out for 5-6 weeks, which is a big blow to this team to start the year. It doesn't impact their playoff hopes, but could do a little damage to their playoff seed at the end of the season. They traded Josh "18 and Under" Giddey to get Caruso. Giddey didn't really have a spot on the team and I don't think they will miss him. SGA will need to maintain his extremely high level of play, while Chet needs to take a jump in his sophomore season... but this team has what it takes to win it all.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Shai Gilgeous-Alexander

SG: Alex Caruso

SF: Lu Dort

PF: Jalen Williams

C: Chet Holmgren

Additions – Isaiah Hartenstein, Alex Caruso

Losses – Josh Giddey, Mike Muscala

#3 – New Orleans Pelicans

General Thoughts – Every year I get fooled by the Pelicans and this year I'm ready to get fooled again. This team looks really good on paper. They added Dejounte Murray, who I think is an excellent point guard. That is one of the primary things this team was missing last year. Obviously, health is always the biggest nag for the Pelicans, especially when it comes to Brandon Ingram/Zion Williamson/Trey Murphy. If by chance they can stay healthy, I think they can be one of the best teams in the West and be a serious contender. Their only significant loss was Jonas Valanciunas, who is a solid big. This leaves them a bit thin at the Center position. They drafted Yves Missi, who I think is very comparable to a Dereck Lively type big. He's extremely long and athletic and won't do much more outside of dunking and blocking shots. They also have Daniel Theis. I'm hoping they are willing to work with Missi and give him a bulk of the minutes, rather than stuffing no-upside Theis out there for 25+ minutes a game. The amount of length and athleticism this team has is so alluring. I'm willing to bet on them this year and say that this will be their year to put it all together. I think they have Western Conference Finals upside.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Dejounte Murray

SG: CJ McCollum

SF: Brandon Ingram

PF: Zion Williamson

C: Herb Jones

Additions – Dejounte Murray, Daniel Theis

Losses – Dyson Daniels, Larry Nance Jr, Jonas Valanciunas, Naji Marshall

#4 – Dallas Mavericks

General Thoughts – All the pieces fell into place for the Mavericks last season, making a great run to the NBA finals, taking down the #4 seed Clippers, #1 seed Thunder, and #3 seed Timberwolves. Luka and Kyrie were at the peak of their game, while an incredible trade deadline yielded them all sorts of valuable role players who helped them achieve that success. That being said, I don't see them being one of the very top seeds in the West. Luka always misses a few games (72-61-66-65-66-70 games in his 6 seasons) and you just never know what you're going to get with Kyrie in the regular season. That's arguably the best 2-man offensive duo in the NBA, and certainly one of the most fun ones to watch. Dallas made rather lateral moves in regards to their depth over the offseason, losing 3 guys but bringing in 4 equal guys. Klay Thompson is obviously the big addition here. It will be so weird to see him in a different jersey. He had become an incredible chucker on Golden State and will need to accept his role on this team. If he does, he could be a real weapon, as I watched Derrick Jones Jr and PJ Washington each shoot about 6 of the most wide-open threes I've seen in my life every single game of the playoffs. I declared that Finn Irving could have filled their role on offense and scored at least 6 or 9 ppg (2/6 or 3/6). That's the magnitude that Kyrie and Luka have. This works two-fold, as lob catchers Dereck Lively and Daniel Gafford sometimes have a field day in the paint. They are both A+ jumpers, and with both of them, one is always in the game as a PnR threat. This team is very good again and definitely could take home the championship. I don't foresee it happening, as it felt like everything went about as good as it could for them last year, but the possibility is most certainly there.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Luka Doncic

SG: Kyrie Irving

SF: Klay Thompson

PF: PJ Washington Jr

C: Daniel Gafford

Additions – Klay Thompson, Quentin Grimes, Naji Marshall, Spencer Dinwiddie

Losses – Tim Hardaway Jr, Derrick Jones Jr, Josh Green

#5 – Denver Nuggets

General Thoughts – My first thought when I see this team is that they are a lot less scary than they have been in the past. Sure, they still have Nikola Jokic, the 3-time MVP, the best player in the league. But their depth, which was once a real strength of the team, is absolutely gone. In fact, they have virtually no depth at all. Additionally, they did almost nothing to address this in the offseason. They lost KCP in the offseason, so Christian Braun will fill his starting position. While I think he is a solid player, that is still a net loss. After the OG four of Murray/Gordon/Porter/Jokic, it's slim pickings. Russell Westbrook's old bones will look to turn back the clock, while young players like Julian Strawther and Peyton Watson will need to take big leaps, as they will be forced into larger roles than they have played in the past. I'm not one to count them out, but this does not look like a championship team to me. I'm surprised they didn't do anything in the offseason. An injury or two to one of their key players could be absolute curtains, as they do not have the depth to recover from it. I wouldn't be surprised if a bit of a "changing of the guard" has arrived in the West, and if they are bounced in the first round. Then again, they have playoff prowess, and enough star power that they could once again make a deep run. Neither would shock me.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Jamal Murray

SG: Christian Braun

SF: Michael Porter Jr.

PF: Aaron Gordon

C: Nikola Jokic

Additions – Dario Saric, Russell Westbrook

Losses – Kentavious Caldwell-Pope, Reggie Jackson, Justin Holiday

#6 – Phoenix Suns

General Thoughts – I bought into the Suns' hype last year and got burned on it. Their "Big 3" of Booker, Beal and Durant played 68, 53, and 75 games, which isn't terrible. I think the biggest

issue on this team is there is just one basketball, and three prolific scorers who need it in their hands. 75 games were the most Durant had played since 2018-19, so they have to feel like they missed the boat a bit on that one, being unable to capitalize on his health. They didn't lose anyone meaningful in the offseason and added Tyus Jones to run point. His ball-distributing ability should help this team out a bit... I would expect he would average a bit more than his 7.3 assists per game last year, maybe 9 or so a game. They resigned Grayson Allen to a big contract in the offseason, which I think was a great signing. Even though I hate him from his time at Duke, he is a very good player, leading the NBA in 3pt% last year at 46.1% on 6 attempts a game. That is an elite weapon to bring off the bench. They drafted Ryan Dunn from UVa, who promptly lit it up in the summer league & preseason, shooting well from 3, which is just unbelievably shocking. I rebounded for him all the time last year and he had me running all over the court chasing his bricks. I'm willing to call beginner's luck on that one, I just cannot truly believe he's gotten that much better so quickly. If he is able to shoot though, he will be an amazing late-first round pick and likely work his way into lots of minutes, thanks to his defensive ability. If everything goes right, this team could make a run, perhaps all the way to the Conference Finals. But I don't think they have what it takes to go any further, with injury-prone stars and a bench that is rather thin. I predict a playoff appearance and a first-round exit, like they did last season.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Tyus Jones

SG: Devin Booker

SF: Bradley Beal

PF: Kevin Durant

C: Jusuf Nurkic

Additions – Tyus Jones, Mason Plumlee, Monte Morris

Losses – Drew Eubanks, Eric Gordon, Damion Lee, Thaddeus Young

#7 – Memphis Grizzlies

General Thoughts – The Grizzlies were just absolutely decimated by the injury bug last year. The season started off poorly thanks to Ja being suspended for brandishing a gun on his Instagram, and it only went downhill from there. Practically every good player they had was hurt at one point or the other at some time during the season. They start the season healthier than they ended it, however some role players like GG Jackson and Vince Williams Jr are already banged up. Ja Morant has potential to be one of the best players in the league, and it would be nice to see him get back to his peak ability. Marcus Smart, Desmond Bane and Jaren Jackson Jr. bring great defensive ability to the table, along with some secondary scoring capability. The most

enticing piece on this team for me is Zach Edey. I will be very interested to watch him play and see how he is able to handle the NBA. I see no reason why he wouldn't make the transition well and be a big contributor on this team. This is a team without much depth, and is clearly injury prone, but if they can stay healthy, they have a lot of pieces and should be back in the playoff picture this season.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Ja Morant

SG: Marcus Smart

SF: Desmond Bane

PF: Jaren Jackson Jr.

C: Zach Edey

Additions – Nobody

Losses – Ziaire Williams, Derrick Rose

#8 – Sacramento Kings

General Thoughts – After a disappointing season last year in which they didn't even make it out of the play-in game, the Kings went out and traded for DeMar DeRozan in the offseason. He effectively takes Harrison Barnes' spot, who they traded away. This is an obvious upgrade, as Barnes is pretty terrible. I have some questions as to how DeRozan's style of play will fit with the fast-paced Kings offense, but he is undoubtedly a good player and a good addition to the team. Their tandem of De'Aaron Fox and Domantas Sabonis is one of the best (and most underrated) in the NBA. Both are excellent players, albeit a bit of defensive liabilities, especially Sabonis. Keon Ellis emerged late in the season as a defensive sparkplug and should see a big increase in minutes. Following the best season of his career in 2022-23, Kevin Huerter had a pretty bad season last year, going from shooting 40.2% from three and averaging 15.2 ppg to 36.1% and 10.2 ppg. It will be important for the Kings to have Red Velvet (one of his listed nicknames on Basketball Reference) back in form this season. Keegan Murray is a great stretch 4, and Malik Monk operates as a microwave style player off the bench. This squad has top 4 seed ability, but in a packed West, I think they have flaws and will find themselves in the back-half of the playoff standings.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: De'Aaron Fox

SG: Keon Ellis

SF: DeMar DeRozan

PF: Keegan Murray

C: Domantas Sabonis

Additions – Demar DeRozan, Doug McDermott

Losses – Davion Mitchell, Sasha Vezenkov, JaVale McGee, Harrison Barnes, Chris Duarte

#9 – Los Angeles Lakers

General Thoughts – I for one am just ecstatic to watch some Lakers' basketball this season. I must see Bronny James on an NBA floor. I think everything about LeBron and Bronny is just hilarious. LeBron is entering his 22nd season and will be turning 40 this December. Everyone is wondering when/if he will ever slow up. He still averaged 25.7 ppg last year and shot a career beset 41% from three, so who knows if he'll ever stop... he's still getting better in some ways! Anthony "ADisney" Davis managed to get his frail bones on the court for 76 games last year; the most in his career and first time playing more than 70 since 2017-18. When he plays, he is certainly one of the best players in the NBA. He is the ultimate X-Factor for this team. Austin Reaves continues to get better for this team, improving his stats across the board in each of his three NBA seasons. For once, the Lakers didn't do much in the offseason... however I sure wish they would have gotten rid of D'Angelo Russell. No team will ever win anything with him on it, he's just a terrible, losing player. There's a reason he's been traded 3 times already. He's on the last year of his contract, and I would not be surprised to see them dump him at the trade deadline. They took Dalton Knecht 17th in the draft, which may end up being the best value pick of the whole draft. I think he is an instant NBA-ready player, who should be able to contribute right away. I'm very interested to see how new coach JJ Redick does, straight off of NBA talk shows. He can't be any worse than Darvin "Hands in his Pockets" Ham, and I actually think he will do really well. I'm not one to count out LeBron, but this team is pretty much the same as last year, which wasn't very good. I think they'll find themselves in the Play-In games once more. Regardless of how they do, I will be eagerly anticipating seeing some Bronny James action & stat lines. I'm sure they will be legendary.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: D'Angelo Russell

SG: Austin Reaves

SF: LeBron James

PF: Rui Hachimura

C: Anthony Davis

Additions – None

Losses – Taurean Prince, Spencer Dinwiddie,

#10 – Houston Rockets

General Thoughts – The Rockets exceeded my expectations for them last year. I thought they would be terrible, but they ended up being ok, finishing 11th in the standings. They bring back the exact same roster, pretty much only adding 3rd overall pick Reed Sheppard. I'm not sure how he fits with this team, and I thought 3rd was a little early for a 6'2" white guy, but he is an elite shooter. Neither Jalen Green nor Jabari Smith Jr seem to be getting much better, they both put up almost identical (or in Green's case, worse) numbers to their 22-23 season. Which is a shame since Smith was the 3rd overall pick and Green the 2nd. I still think Fred VanVleet is just awful. His career FG% is a despondent 40.4%, which has to be one of the worst of all time. Alp Sengun is their star player. If they want to build a contender, it has to start through him. The gap between him and the likes of Domantas Sabonis and Nikola Jokic is smaller than most would think. He was putting together a masterful season last year, averaging 21.1/9.3/5.0 before injuring himself with about 20 games left in the season. I've also heard rumblings that a big breakout season for Amen Thompson is in the books. I will tentatively buy into that hype. If he can learn to shoot at all, I think he could be a force for this team. I think this team could be good enough to sneak into the play-in games, but no better than that. Ime Udoka is an excellent coach and should be able to get the most out of this squad. They have a few pieces, but still have a lot of losing players on the team, and will need to siphon them out before they ever become legit again.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Fred VanVleet

SG: Jalen Green

SF: Dillon Brooks

PF: Jabari Smith Jr.

C: Alperen Sengun

Additions – None

Losses – Reggie Bullock, Boban Marjanovic

#11 – Golden State Warriors

General Thoughts – “Turn out the lights, the party’s over. They say that all good things must end.” When I see this Golden State roster, I just hear Granddad singing his old tune. As sad as it is for me to say, this team is just not very good. They finally got rid of Klay, who had just turned into the worst player ever. It is very sad to see the Splash Bros separated after all these years, as they were my all-time favorite duo. But it was a necessary decision. The first thing that jumps out at me is that Draymond is the projected starting Center on this team. The Warriors have played small-ball for a long time, but it is getting less and less effective. It would have been nice if they signed a half-decent big man. They made some solid moves in the offseason, picking up some veterans in Hield, Melton and Anderson. None of them are going to be game-changers, however. If this team wants to make a playoff run, or even just a playoff appearance, it is going to take 2 things. Steph is going to have to put up yet another incredible season. He has continued to deliver, maybe even just putting up the most iconic moment of his career this summer in the 2024 Olympics, but at 36, you have to wonder how long he can keep it up. Brandin Podziemski and Jonathan Kuminga are going to have to each take a big leap this year. Podziemski had a very good rookie season and is an effective, hard-nosed player. Kuminga continues to improve little-by-little each year... but it’s put up or shut up time now. He has star potential and needs to show it this season. I don’t see this team making the playoffs this year, I don’t think they have enough talent. But I know never to count out Steph, Draymond & Steve Kerr, and will certainly be rooting for one last heroic playoff run.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Steph Curry

SG: Brandon Podziemski

SF: Andrew Wiggins

PF: Jonathan Kuminga

C: Draymond Green

Additions – De’Anthony Melton, Kyle “Slo-Mo” Anderson, Buddy “Horse-Face” Hield

Losses – Klay Thompson, Chris Paul, Dario Saric

#12 – Los Angeles Clippers

General Thoughts – The Clippers blew their best playoff opportunity they have had in several years last season, losing to the Mavericks in the first round in 6 games. They had been playing really good basketball and were a popular pick to emerge from the West. Now, they’ve lost Paul George in free agency and Kawhi Leonard is already having all sorts of issues before the season begins. James Harden will be tasked with carrying the weight for this team, but at 35 he is showing signs of regression. His stats dropped across the board last year. They added Derrick

Jones Jr, who had a huge breakout last year with the Mavericks and should be a great contributor to this team. They also added Kevin Porter Jr, who is back in the NBA after missing last year since he beat the daylights out of his girlfriend. He averaged 19ppg in 2022-23 and could be a sneaky good addition. LAC is chock full of veterans and should be extremely boring to watch. I know I won't be watching them at all, I can't stand James Harden. I don't think this is a good team even with Kawhi... but without him, I certainly don't see them making the playoffs.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: James Harden

SG: Norman Powell

SF: Terrance Mann

PF: Derrick Jones Jr

C: Ivica Zubac

Additions – Derrick Jones Jr, Nicolas Batum, Kevin Porter Jr, Kris Dunn

Losses – Paul George, Mason Plumlee, Daniel Theis, Russell Westbrook, PJ Tucker

#13 – Portland Trailblazers

General Thoughts – I could talk myself into believing that this team could be half-decent. They have some good pieces. Players like Anfernee Simons and Jerami Grant can tide them over for the time being. They have the ability to go out and get buckets. Scoot Henderson started out the year abysmally... but his numbers got better across the board as the year went on, averaging 16.6/3.5/7.1 in 20 games after the All-Star Break. If they want to be good going forwards, it will be essential that he continues to progress. On the season, he shot a very poor 38.5/32.5/81.9 slash line. That will be the primary area in which he needs to take a jump in his sophomore season. He is only 20 years old and I believe has a bright future ahead of him. I think drafting Donovan Clingan was a great choice. All he did in college was play two seasons and win two National Championships at UConn. The dude knows how to win, and he will be their big of the future. Coinciding with this, they need to get rid of DeAndre "Locker Room Cancer" Ayton as fast as they possibly can. He is no good and carries a massive ego with him. He will only drag this team down. They would benefit more from throwing Clingan into the fire and letting him figure it out on the court. Lastly, I think trading for Deni Avdija was a sneaky good move. He is only 23 years old, and was really coming into his own down the stretch for the Wizards last year (17.1/8.9/3.9 in 21 games post-ASB). I don't think this team will be good yet... they still need a few more pieces of the puzzle. But I do think they are moving in the proper direction and will be back in the playoffs in the near future... and it wouldn't surprise me if they are better than expected this year.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Scoot Henderson

SG: Anfernee Simons

SF: Deni Avdija

PF: Jerami Grant

C: De'Andre Ayton

Additions – Deni Avdija, Bryce McGowens

Losses – Malcolm Brogdon

#14 – Utah Jazz

General Thoughts – I'm not sure what the plan is for this team. They seem to be one of the teams that is most "Stuck in the middle" of anyone. They have an odd collection of players. Regardless, this team is going to be pretty awful this year. Players like Collin Sexton and Lauri Markkanen have the ability to put up good statistics, but are not good players. For whatever reason, they don't like to start Walker Kessler... who I believe is the piece they could build around. He is a shot-blocking machine and desperately needs to play more minutes. This team is filled with terrible young players, such as their three draft picks (Cody Williams, Isaiah Collier, Kyle Filipowski), and terrible old players, such as Patty Mills and Jordan Clarkson. Their two top draft picks from 2023 (Keyonte George and Taylor Hendricks) are both slated to be in the starting lineup to begin this year, which should give them a chance to prove themselves. There is a 0% chance this team is any good, and I suspect they will challenge the Spurs for the last spot in the West.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Keyonte George

SG: Collin Sexton

SF: Lauri Markkanen

PF: Taylor Hendricks

C: John Collins

Additions – Drew Eubanks, Patty Mills

Losses – Talen Horton-Tucker, Omer Yurtseven, Kris Dunn

#15 – San Antonio Spurs

General Thoughts – Obviously, the Spurs have the prodigy, the next chosen one, the 7’5” freak of nature that is Victor Wembanyama. He was everything that he was cut out to be and then some in his rookie year, putting up statlines that seemed impossible and recording highlights that looked fake. I expect him to continue to get better and better. However, the rest of this team is still terrible. They added 2 spry young pups in Chris Paul and Harrison Barnes. That just doesn’t push the needle for me. They still have Keldon “The Black Hole” Johnson who loves hoisting up shots at a low low clip (45.4% FG%). Devin Vassell was signed to a big contract, so they clearly see him in their future plans. I don’t think he is all that, and he is also already dinged up and will be missing time to start the year. Stephon Castle was a good draft pick and should play a role in his rookie season. All in all, I trust the Spurs to build around Wemby and turn into a contender eventually. But it will not be this year... and they still have a ways to go.

Projected Starters (ESPN)

PG: Chris Paul

SG: Devin Vassell

SF: Harrison Barnes

PF: Jeremy Sochan

C: Victor Wembanyama

Additions – Chris Paul, Harrison Barnes, Malachi “50 Burger” Flynn

Losses – Cedi Osman, Devonte Graham